

Story Thirteen

There was nothing inherently wrong with it. It was not particularly alarming or frightening or even that interesting. In reality, nothing had changed. Yet it marked the world's end.

It was a normal day for me, I had gotten out of bed at 7:30 in the morning and went to the bathroom to brush my teeth. After getting ready for the day and eating a hearty breakfast of scrambled eggs, bacon, and yogurt, I stepped outside into the cool fall air and got into my car, which faced the street. I looked through the windshield of my car and noticed a sizable black line running vertically down the glass. However, when I leaned forward to get a better look, the crack I suspected to be in my windshield moved with me. That is when I realized it. I stepped out of my car and looked up into the pale blue atmosphere. The sky was cracked.

A large black line running vertically down the sky itself, too thin to reveal anything behind it, but wide enough to be clearly seen by everyone below. Soon, others walked outside and followed in my footsteps. Simply going to get the newspaper, getting in one's car to drive to work, walking one's dog, all resulted with yet another person staring transfixed at the cracked sky above. Something so inconceivable and unbelievable, as if in a painting or a cartoon, brought to life by an unknown force of nature. We would have been fools not to fear it, right?

Suffice to say there were not many people at work that day. It was a bizarre event for sure, but it did not stop me from driving to my place of employment. The lack of traffic on the road actually made it easier to get to work on time. I sat down at my desk and turned on my outdated computer, wanting nothing more than to get that crack off my mind. I looked around my small office floor. Of the fifteen or so desks I could see, only eight were filled, and the people who were here did not seem to be very productive. Were these people as worried as I was? And what about the people who were not at work. They were probably at home anticipating and preparing for the worse. I was in no way ready for the worse, I'd have to steal from these people if I wanted to survive. Hell, I might even need to kill these people.

I immediately shook away the idea and silently reprimanded myself for even thinking about doing something so horrible. I tried to focus back on my work but I could not get the crack out of my head. Even our workaholic boss, Susan, was inattentive, staring out her window at the crack in the sky. I doubted that I would be able to get anything done today even if I tried. I went on my phone and opened Twitter, seeing nothing but posts asking what was wrong with the sky.

"Hell, if you aren't working then something really must be wrong," the voice of my deskmate Kenny broke my concentration. Of all the people that stayed home, why couldn't he be one of them?

"You're trying to figure out what that thing in the sky is, aren't you?" Kenny asked smugly, as if only he was clever enough to come to that conclusion.

"By the tone in your voice it sounds like you know what it is," I shot back, immediately wishing I had ended the conversation instead. Kenny grinned as he wheeled his swivel chair right next to me, showing me his yellowing teeth and basking me in his sickly sweet breath.

"You know how the government has been secretly working on a new spaceship that can travel faster than the speed of light," Kenny said quietly. I turned back to my computer. Kenny, not taking the very obvious hint, continued on.

"Well I suspect they finally got it working and sent it into space. It probably went so fast that it ripped a hole in the sky!" I turned back to him, irritation plain on my face.

"So a piece of technology that does not exist did this? Sounds probable." Kenny's face flushed a little with anger.

"Then you explain the crack in the sky," he said as he swiveled his chair back to his side of the desk. He was right. His theory was ridiculous, but at least he had a theory.

At 12:30 we all gathered in the break room to eat lunch, even Susan joined us. I suppose she did not want to eat alone on a day like today. Our tiny break room tv displayed a pair of confused hosts trying to go on with their normal news routine. The crack in the sky was ever-present, but it was not very eventful.

"In more pressing news however, a riot has broken out outside of the White House gates after police tried to shut down a group of protesters who wanted answers to the crack in the sky," One of the hosts started to say as the other put his finger to his ear. His hand shot up, signaling for the first host to stop.

"Hold on Katlyn, I have just received word that the president is about to make a formal announcement concerning the crack, let's take a look." The male reporter pointed towards the screen which quickly cut from the cheap looking set of the news show to the outside of the White House. The president stood on a stage behind a large wooden podium, his hands holding the sides of the podium calmly. He looked tired, and I could just barely make out dark circles under his eyelids. Everyone in the break room went silent as the president opened his mouth to speak.

"As you are most likely aware, there is a large black line in the sky we currently presume to be a crack," he said in an oddly shaky voice, one much different than his usual one. "We would like to take this moment to assure you that there is no reason to be alarmed. He has personally promised me that he will not hurt anyone so there is no reason to be worried. Thank you for your cooperation and have a good day." The video cut back to the two news hosts who both looked at the camera confused and somewhat afraid. The female host quickly switched back to a fake smile and tried to continue on as the male host soon followed suit.

"What the fuck was that!" Kenny said slowly as he stood up. "They're hiding something from us, man. 'He won't hurt us? What does that even mean? That lunatic is either hiding something from us, or he's gone completely insane.'" Kenny stormed out of the breakroom. Our receptionist Patricia tried to get up to stop him but was kept down by Susan's hand on her shoulder.

"Just let him burn off some steam," she said in a much softer tone than usual. Patricia, taken aback, stayed seated and continued watching the tv. As much as I hated to admit it, Kenny was right again. That was a terrible explanation. Susan let us all go home after that, it seemed like the president's insanity made her rethink the severity of our situation. There were a lot more cars on the road than before, it seemed like people were stocking up on supplies in case something happened. Though I did not think a crack in the sky really warranted doomsday level preparation, the fact that so many people were doing it worried me. If something really did happen I would have nothing. I tried to block it all out as I continued home, making a mental note to grab supplies if things got worse. I pulled into my driveway and stepped out of my car, looking up to the sky once more to examine the crack. I could see a cloud roll in behind it, as if the sky was simply a video playing on a cracked screen.

I opened my door and stepped inside, putting down my things and sitting down in a torn and faded recliner. I wanted to relax, but I could not seem to forget about the crack. I turned the tv on and flipped to a channel playing a rerun of an old sitcom. I tried watching it but the commotion outside kept on grabbing my attention. It seemed so odd to be acting as if everything was normal while people outside were panicking. How could that many people simply be overreacting, if there was truly nothing to worry about, then why would so many people think otherwise. How could that many people be wrong? I flipped back to the news channel.

"As you can see," a worried looking reporter started in front of a crowded supermarket, "the president's statement did not have much of a calming effect on the people of Philadelphia. This is just one of the many supermarkets flooded with worried consumers, scrambling to get the last of the available supplies." I looked back out to the crowded streets of my neighborhood. The closest supermarket would probably be too crowded, plus I would be going nowhere in this traffic, but there was a grocery store that would only be five minutes away by bike. It couldn't hurt to grab some supplies before they all ran out, plus all I'm doing right now is worrying about the crack. With that I stood up, put on my jacket, and walked back to my garage to grab my bike.

Somehow my neighborhood grocery store was even more crowded than the supermarket in Philadelphia, I suppose everyone had the same idea as me. The aisles were packed with people all clamoring to buy even one can of preserved fruit or baked beans. I was barely able to get enough food to last a week, and that was even if I rationed it out. The sea of people brushing past me and snapping at what little food I had only served to remind of what might happen if and when all the food runs out. I made sure to pick up a sharp carving knife just in case. By the time I was able to push past the insane number of people crowded into such a small space, the sky started to darken. I looked at my watch to see that it was barely 3 o'clock. Perhaps it was a trick of the eye, maybe the sky was especially cloudy and it was going to rain, or maybe it was a sign of something worse to come. I bought my comparatively small amount of rations and walked

outside to find my bike gone. I decided to stop by a hardware store to pick up some wooden boards and nails on my way back home.

"As the scared and ravenous customers of stores and supermarkets have had their needs seen to, the aggressive feeling in the air has finally begun to die down," the young reporter continued in a much less worried tone. I felt a lot better now, knowing that I would be safe at home until this whole thing blew over. With the rations I had picked up at the store, I had enough food to last for a month and had boarded up all of the windows on my first floor. The light of street lamps seeped in through the space between the boards on the window to my right. The commotion outside seemed to die down too, and now that I had everything I needed, I began to feel a little silly. Of course nothing was going to happen, I was only over-reacting to the overreaction of others. The fact that I was one of the only houses on my street with boarded windows proved that. My thoughts were interrupted by the reporter on tv.

"I've just gotten word that the vice president is about to make an announcement himself, we'll show that now," the reporter said, sounding a little nervous. The feed cut to the vice president, looking tired, but much better than the president had. He was standing at the same podium the president had stood at in the afternoon. He was clutching onto the podium's sides and his knuckles were white. He spoke in the hoarse voice of someone who had been talking all day.

"Citizens of the United States of America, I along with the United States Government would like to formally apologize for today's remarks by the president. To the best of our knowledge, the president has come down with an illness that is being treated now. On his behalf I would like to personally assure the public that there is nothing to worry about. The black line in the sky is nothing more than a natural anomaly and should not be seen as anything more. This anomaly should not stop you from going about your everyday lives, and should not make you worry about gathering food and supplies. We assure you that nothing will come of this. Thank you for listening." With that the vice president relaxed his grip on the podium and gave a reassuring smile. I let out a sigh of relief and leaned back in my cushiony chair. The president was just sick, and the crack had nothing to do with it. At least now I could get a half decent night's sleep.

I'm not sure exactly what I expected to see when I stepped outside the next day, but I did not expect the crack to be wider.

Nevertheless, like the good samaritan I am, I drove down a road slightly more crowded than last morning and walked into work with a look of neutrality on my face. It was not until I stepped into the heated building which housed my office that I realized how cold it was outside. It was fall but it felt more like winter. I looked back up at the sky as I entered my office building. I could see a sliver of pitch black darkness hidden behind the crack, like I was looking into a starless night sky. It was too thin to make out anything in detail though.

Almost everyone was at work that day, thankfully with the exception of Kenny. I sat down at my desk and began to start the work I should have finished yesterday. Luckily it seemed like everyone was on the same page as me, diligently typing away at their dirty keyboards, the only talking coming from people on the phone. The boring monotony of it all actually made me smile, yet I still felt weird. Many of these same people that I was sitting next to were the people I was afraid to death of just hours ago, the same people I would have taken food from, the same people I thought of killing. Did a part of me still want the world to be descending into chaos? At the very least it would be more interesting than what was happening now. Did they feel the same way, or was I just going crazy? Is the crack making me think this way, or is this just me.

During lunch we all sat in the breakroom, eagerly awaiting an explanation for the crack opening.

"It's probably a rip in the ozone layer. We all knew it was happening, we just didn't know what it would look like."

"So you're saying that clouds exist outside of our atmosphere?"

"It probably is just a natural anomaly that we don't understand. How do you think cavemen felt when they first saw lightning?"

"Yea but lightning doesn't last for this long, plus how come it's never happened before?"

"It has to be a black hole, have you seen how black it is?"

"Then how come we aren't all dead right now, it looks like it's no more than a mile away."

"This is just proof that we live inside a virtual reality. Our reality is breaking right in front of us." Surprisingly enough, that was the only theory no one had a comeback for.

"I know what it is," a quiet voice said from the back of the breakroom. We all turned to see the short body of one of the accountants no one had ever bothered to learn the name of.

"Don't you all see it? It's a crack in the sky that no one person can comprehend. It's an opening into heaven. It is our way to God." No one really wanted to talk about the crack after that.

The news hosts on tv only seemed to talk about stories that were no longer important, an incoming hurricane in Florida, a possible mole in the White House. Nothing was as important as the crack, even the hosts knew that. They spoke in anxious voices, just as eager for news on the crack as we were. The female reporter quickly cut off the male reporter halfway into his story on contaminated drinking water.

"George, I have to stop you there because I have just received word that the vice president is about to make another announcement concerning the crack." The feed immediately cut to the vice president sitting in a fancy looking office behind a furnished desk. He looked worse than he had yesterday, almost as if he had been awake all night. He had to clear his throat before he began to speak.

"Good citizens of the United States of America, I would like to once again reiterate that there is nothing to worry about. The line in the sky is simply a natural occurrence, and it being

just a little larger does not change that. Please continue your day as usual and keep this in mind. As long as you do not panic, no one else will. Thank you." The feed cut back to the news hosts, looking exactly how I felt, disappointed.

The room quickly flooded with complaints from my coworkers.

"He just regurgitated what he had said last night."

"That doesn't explain why the crack is larger."

"What's going on with the president, is he still sick?" These questions continued on, but there was only one question that I had, a question that had been bothering me ever since the vice president's first speech.

"Why won't he just admit that it's a crack?"

Despite my day being fairly normal again, I still could not seem to relax. Questions knocked around in my head and fears crept up my spine and into my brain, taunting me with their impossible nature but possible inevitability. The young reporter who had once given me some sense of solace, now only shared my worried confusion. People who had chosen not to get supplies yesterday were repeating the actions of those who had. I looked up at the dark sky to see the crack once again. The pure blackness behind the crack taunted me. I desperately wanted answers to what else laid behind it, but at the same time, I feared that I would not be able to comprehend what I saw. What did the president mean when he referred to it as a 'he'? Was it some sort of creature? Was it an alien from another plain of existence that figured out a way to get to us? I suppose the only way to truly find out is to wait.

I guess I should have seen it coming, a part of me probably knew it was going to happen, but it managed to scare me half to death anyways.

The next morning I stepped outside to see that the crack had opened up more, revealing a completely black surface. The area of black closest to the crack actually seemed to be tinted blue, as if the area behind the crack was mixing with the sky. The image looked so familiar, yet it was still too thin to make out. Nevertheless I drove to work, not even paying attention to how many other people were on the road. The air was cold again, but that part didn't really surprise me.

I think less people were at work than yesterday, but I couldn't really tell. I sat back down at my computer and began my work like I had done every other day before this damn crack had appeared. It seemed like no one else was having the problem I had, or were they just hiding it well? I could barely focus on anything. How could I go about my everyday life like this, my mind constantly wandering from one subject to the next until it finally landed back on the crack. Was this ranting in my brain just a way for me to keep from imagining its image? Would I ever be able to act normal again, or would this be something I hid for the rest of my life? Why am I even hiding it? Everyone knows that there's a giant crack in the sky leading to god knows where.

"Why the hell won't anyone say anything about the giant fucking crack in the sky?"

I paused for a moment and looked around. Did I really just say that out loud? The short accountant in the back of the room stood up on his chair, shifting the glaring pressure of everyone's eyes off of me.

"Charlie is right! Why is our government telling us to pretend that everything is normal when it is obviously not? God himself is opening up the gates of heaven to spread his good word and we're just supposed to ignore him? Why are we listening to an insane leader and his corrupt underlings when a higher power has already spoken? Break free of these earthly chains and join me!" The accountant jumped off his seat and marched to the front door. At first no one moved. Susan ran out of her office, seeing what was taking place, and tried to stop the determined accountant.

"You can't just leave work in the middle of the day, unless you want to lose your job," She said confidently with her hands on her hips. The accountant looked at Susan with disdain plastered on his face.

"So?" Our receptionist Patricia piped up. Now the glaring pressure was on her, and she was clearly uncomfortable. She blushed and looked down at her hands shyly.

"Well, something strange is clearly happening, what's the point of just sitting here and letting it happen? That crack in the sky is opening up fast, and whatever is on the other side is going to come through, good or bad." Susan stood still thinking of a reply that would end this whole discussion. "You're part of this too, you know, we all are," Patricia continued, "I don't think an unexplainable crack in the sky cares whether you're our boss or not." The pressure now shifted to Susan, standing between us and the exit. She sighed and stepped aside, letting the accountant through. Patricia slowly followed him out, still staring at the floor, and soon more people followed in their footsteps. I sat still, not sure whether to be proud or ashamed that I instigated an office walkout I had no desire to partake in. I guess I was a little bit of both.

The accountant, who I did not know the name of, knelt in the middle of the street under the gray, cracked sky, seemingly praying. A few people drove home, whether to prepare for the worst or to just enjoy a day off, I do not know. Some of my co-workers joined the accountant in prayer, one of them clearly unsure of what he was supposed to be doing. Patricia just looked up at the crack in awe and fear. I ended up joining her as we both stared into the familiar white and colored light that hid behind the open crack. I could see smaller cracks branching off to the sides, seemingly ready to break open. The sky's color seemed so strange to me, it almost looked like it was tinted red. Susan soon joined Patricia and I, and as we all stared into the thin hole in our sky, I began to wonder. How the hell is my life supposed to go on?

I decided to drive home after the sky began to turn dark. It didn't feel very late to me, it must have been around noon, yet the sky seemed to do what it wanted. Nature wasn't doing what it was supposed to, maybe it was a rip in the atmosphere. The roads were barren, anyone who wasn't at work was probably huddled up at home with their doors locked at windows bolted.

Nothing was normal anymore. I decided to go back to the grocery store and pick up some more food. Once the hole fully opens I'll never put a foot outside. Luckily I hadn't taken the boards off my windows yet. All I'll need is food and water. I'll buy enough that I'll never need to work again, then I'll lock myself away and be safe from the world. God I sound insane, but how could I not while staring at a hole in the sky.

I entered my house for what would hopefully be the last time that night, at least it looked like night, it couldn't have been more than an hour since I left work. I had enough water to last for over a month after my faucets shut off, and enough food to last twice as long. I cracked open a beer to take my mind off things and turned on my tv. The two news hosts that were always on in the afternoon sat before me in their cheap studio spouting the same nonsense they did everyday. I waited eagerly for any news on the crack as I took a sip of my beer. Minutes passed by slowly and as they did, the hosts themselves seemed to get more disappointed. Just as I thought there would be no announcements today, the female reporter held her hand to her ear and motioned towards someone offscreen. Before she even got the chance to say anything, the footage cut to the vice-president sitting in a wooden chair in a dark room, its windows covered by heavy drapes.

"Good afternoon citizens of the United States. I would like to formally apologize for the lack of explanation on our part, we have been rather vague in our explanation of the thing in the sky, but that is only because the reasons for its existence are simple. It is a natural event, nothing more. Our top scientists and researchers have investigated the situation and have found no reason for worry. We thank you for your cooperation and continued loyalty in these trying times." The vice-president spoke in a tired voice throughout his statement and his eyes seemed to twitch whenever he mentioned the crack in the sky. The feed cut back to the two hosts. The female host began to speak.

"So, as you can tell, there is nothing to..." she trailed off as her hands balled into tightly clenched fists. Her co-host looked at someone off screen confused. The female host snapped up again.

"No! We can't just lie to everyone and pretend that everything is normal!" She yelled at the people just offscreen. "Whatever is behind that crack is danger-" The video cut to a commercial. I stared blankly at the tv, before standing up and looking through the space between the boards on my window. The cracks which had branched off from the thin hole in the sky were now broken open, white light streaming out from just beyond. The sky was tinted red, I was sure of that now.

A knocking on my door startled me out of my trance. The channel I was on was still playing commercials. I slowly got up from my cushiony chair and rubbed my sore neck. The knocking persisted as I made my way over to the door. I looked through the peephole in my door, seeing the image of Patricia.

"What do you want?" I asked, only slightly hiding the irritation in my voice and very reluctant to open the door.

"Can you please let me in, my landlord completely locked down his building and won't let anyone in." Patricia pleaded. "I have a bunch of food in my car, and it's just outside if that's what you're worried about."

"Why don't you get someone else to let you stay at their place, don't you have any friends or family around?" I asked, my body still glued to the door, staring out the peephole. Patricia looked down at her feet, blushing from embarrassment.

"I don't really have any friends, and the only family I have lives in Maine." She tried to make eye contact with me but I could tell it was a struggle for her. I couldn't help but feel bad for her, she was in a hard spot and I was shrugging her off. It wasn't her fault there was a giant hole in the sky.

"Then go to Maine," I said in the coldest voice I could muster as I stepped away from the door.

"Please, I don't want to be left alone!" She yelled from beyond the door. I froze in place, realizing that we were both in the same position. I opened my door and she quickly jumped inside.

"Thank you," She sighed with relief as she threw her arms around me to embrace in a hug. I calmed down a bit, realizing that she was just a scared young girl. Now that the door was open I could clearly see the outside, and the empty street behind her.

"I thought you said your car was just outside," I said slowly as I could feel her grip around me tighten. A sharp pain shot up my spine as I could feel her knife slide into my back. She slipped the knife out and pushed me backwards onto the hardwood floor as she quickly ran into my kitchen. I reached my arms out and tried to turn myself over. With each move I made an icy pain shook my body to its very core. I slowly crawled over to my chair, wincing each time my hand pounded the floor and dragged my limp body forward. I grabbed onto the arm of my cushiony chair and used what little strength I had left to pull myself up to my feet. I wobbled momentarily but kept myself from falling over. I reached into the right side of my couch cushions before hearing footsteps rushing back in my direction. Patricia ran back out of the kitchen carrying three heavy bags of canned goods and water. I turned and lunged at her, stabbing my carving knife deep into her neck. We both fell backwards, bleeding heavily. Patricia didn't last very long. I stumbled my way to the door, locking it and making my way to the bathroom. I passed out pretty quickly after that.

"Citizens of the United States of America, do not be alarmed. The thing in the sky will not hurt you, there is nothing to fear," The vice president said in a plain voice. I slowly opened my eyes and stretched my arms. The image on the tv showed the vice president sitting in some sort of concrete bunker. I slowly lifted my back off the back of my chair, dried blood peeling off the stretched leather of the chair.

"The only thing that can hurt us is our own fear, please do not panic." The man on the tv continued. I stood up and adjusted to my surroundings. I could hear screaming and car alarms coming from outside, muffled by my closed windows. I stiffly moved to my boarded up window and peered outside. The streets were filled with cars and running people. A car had been flipped over in the middle of the road and there were a few cars trying to push it out of the way. "There is nothing for you to fear," the tv continued. It seemed like the majority of people had simply abandoned their cars and were now running wildly down the street. One person out of the mob of people began banging on one of my neighbor's doors. The occupant replied to the banging by kicking open the door and shooting the person. "The only thing that can hurt us is our own fear," the tv repeated. Others in the mob of people noticed this and ran at the now terrified man who held the gun. He tried to close his door but was too slow. The mob of people broke into his house and I could just barely hear his screams added into the chaos of noise. "Please do n-" I turned off the tv.

The sky was a deep shade of red, and the crack was open. I looked up into the space beyond, and the creature's giant eye stared back at me. Its eye was so human, perhaps it was the eye of God. Perhaps it was only here to observe us. My thoughts melded together as I could feel my brain melt. At least that's what it felt like, I couldn't really tell. Was I going crazy? The screaming blocked out everything else, even my hearing, even my thoughts, even my sight. I stared into the eye and the screams of every human on earth, living and dead, stared back. I was going crazy. The cacophony of noise cracked open my skull and split open my ears. God was watching us, and he wanted us all to die. I understood now, that was the problem, I understood everything. Knowledge filled my head and stuffed my brain. But how could it do that if my skull was cracked open? How was I even thinking right now, I thought my brain had melted? I can't tell. I can't tell anything anymore. I can't even tell how long I have been staring at this eye, or how long it has been staring back. What's the point of living if you know everything, if you have seen God.

Fuck, I need a drink.